THE RIDER · No.13

CRAFT · MUSIC DATA SCIENCE

YOUR CROWD IS ON AUTOPLAY.

THE TASTE GAP WORKSHEET.

The industry says streaming killed the DJ as tastemaker. Spotify's own researchers found something more useful: the music people are fed is narrower than the music they choose. Lean-back listening has a comfort zone. In the room, you're the one doing the programming. That's not your obituary. It's your job description.

WHAT'S IN THIS EDITION

01	**THE CASE**	What the research actually found
02	**THE TWIST**	Where it gets complicated, and why that helps you
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04	**THE TASTE GAP WORKSHEET**	Map the comfort zone, plan the stretch
05	**THE BRIDGE-TRACK PLANNER**	Familiar → adjacent → new, plus the crowd read
06	**BY CONTEXT**	Club, wedding and sangeet, corporate, open-format bar
07	**LIMITS · GO DEEPER**	What this doesn't mean, and the sources

> This is a working craft guide, not prescriptive advice. The research describes listeners on streaming platforms, not dancefloors. Use it to think, then trust your ears.

Compiled by Vic Naik · The Vic Fix · 19 years, 18+ countries.

01 · THE CASE

STREAMING MADE TASTE WIDER. THE FEED MADE IT NARROWER.

Both are true. Here's the evidence, kept separate from our reading of it.

WHAT THE RESEARCH FOUND

1. Streaming opened the doors.
Marketing scientists followed a panel of about 5,000 listeners before and after they adopted Spotify. Once people switched from buying music to streaming it, they played more music, more different artists and more new music. The effect faded over the months but was still there half a year later.

Datta, Knox & Bronnenberg, Marketing Science, 2018.

2. But the feed is narrower than the search.
Spotify's own researchers (four Spotify scientists and a University of Toronto professor) measured how spread out each listener's music was. The data covered over 100 million Premium users and around 70 billion streams in July 2019. “Spread out” meant how far apart a person's songs sit on a map built from 850 million+ playlists. They split every stream in two:

- **Organic:** you searched for it, saved it, or played someone's playlist.
- **Programmed:** Spotify chose it. That covers personalised mixes like Discover Weekly, radio, and Spotify's editorial playlists.

The finding, in their words: user-driven listening “is almost always more diverse than algorithmically-driven listening.” People whose taste widened over the following year got there by steering their own listening more and leaning on programmed listening less.

Anderson et al., The Web Conference (WWW '20), 2020, §4.1 and §5.2.

3. Wide listeners are the valuable ones.
At the same activity level, the listeners with the widest taste were up to **25 percentage points less likely to leave** Spotify and up to **35 percentage points more likely to become paying subscribers**. The authors are clear this is a correlation. Wide listening might simply be what serious music lovers do.

Anderson et al., §4.3.

4. Lean-back is a big habit.
When Spotify launched its AI DJ, it said that on days people used it, they spent **25% of their listening time** with it.

Spotify newsroom, May 2023 (company figure, early users).

> **OUR READING**
> The platform's programmed listening is optimised to give people more of what's close to what they already like. That works: people stream more. But the widest listeners, and the most loyal ones, are the ones who go off-feed. Breadth is the high-value behaviour, and the feed doesn't produce much of it on its own.

02 · THE TWIST

IT'S NOT HUMAN VS. MACHINE. IT'S ACTIVE VS. AUTOPLAY.

Here's the part the hot takes leave out, and it's the part that matters most for you.

On Spotify, the "narrow" bucket includes humans.
Spotify's editorial playlists, picked by people, count as programmed in that study. So the finding isn't "algorithms narrow, humans widen". It's listening someone programs for you is narrower than listening you steer yourself.

On Deezer, the algorithm went the other way.
A study of 8,639 Deezer subscribers in France across 2019 found:

- Algorithmic picks nudged people toward **less famous** artists.
- Human editorial playlists nudged them toward the **most famous** ones.
- The listeners who relied most on their own choices repeated the same songs the most.

The researchers' conclusion: there's "no blanket answer". They call it filter niches, not filter bubbles.

Villermet et al., ACM RecSys 2021.

AND THE MOST REPETITIVE PROGRAMMERS OF ALL? RADIO.

The same study compared listeners with 39 French radio stations. Most stations repeated themselves more than the listeners did. Two stations beat everyone on variety: **FIP and France Musique**, two French public stations known for playlists that jump across genres and decades.

THE PATTERN UNDER ALL OF IT

One finding holds across both platforms: whatever mode a listener leans on most is where they repeat themselves most (Villermet et al.).

Comfort zones aren't made by algorithms. They're made by **not choosing**. The feed, the hits radio station and the safe wedding playlist are all the same animal.

What that means for a DJ: you're not the antidote to programmed listening. **You are programmed listening.** For the length of your set, the room has handed you the remote. You can be the mainstream hits station, or you can be the FIP: the human choice that goes somewhere the room wouldn't have gone alone.

Tastemaking didn't die. It moved from "what you play first" to how far you take people from where they started.

03 · IN THE BOOTH

THE ROOM ARRIVES WITH A COMFORT ZONE. YOUR SET DECIDES WHAT THEY LEAVE WITH.

Your crowd walked in after a week of autoplay. Here's what we think that means for the set. **This is craft interpretation, not research.**

01 **The comfort zone is your opening currency, not your enemy.**
Familiar music buys trust. (Ep 11 covered why the first three tracks are what the room remembers.) Spend that trust, but don't stay in it all night.

02 **Stretch in steps, not jumps.**
Spotify's own maps place songs close together when people put them on the same playlists. Use the same logic in the booth: move to something adjacent before something new. A jump from the chart hit to the deep cut loses the room. A bridge carries it.

03 **The stretch is the part only you can do.**
Any phone can play the comfort zone. The bit of your set that widens the room is the bit no feed was going to serve them. That's what makes it yours.

04 **Measure the stretch, then grow it.**
Most DJs never decide how much of a set is “new to this room”. Decide it. Write it down. Raise it when the room trusts you, and pull it back when it doesn't.

05 **Breadth isn't randomness.**
The Spotify researchers themselves note that “diverse” can range from well-curated to completely random, and only one of those is a skill. A wide set still has a spine: a groove, a language, an era or a mood that ties the detours together.

> **THE RULE OF THE STRETCH**
>
> **Familiar earns the right. Adjacent builds the bridge. New is the reason they booked a human.**

04 · THE TASTE GAP WORKSHEET

MAP THE COMFORT ZONE. PLAN THE STRETCH.

Fill this in before the gig. It takes ten minutes. The point is to decide how far you'll take this room before you're in the booth.

PART A · THE ROOM'S COMFORT ZONE (WHAT'S ALREADY ON THEIR AUTOPLAY)

Gig / venue / slot: _____

e.g. Koramangala bar, Friday, 9pm–1am, open format

Age range of the crowd: _____

Languages they'll sing along to: _____

e.g. Hindi, Punjabi, English, Kannada

Five tracks this crowd has almost certainly streamed this month:

1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____

4. _____ 5. _____

What these tracks share: _____

groove / language / era / energy / vocal

Not on their feed, but they could love: _____

PART B · THE STRETCH

My stretch share for this set: _____

% or number of tracks new to this room. Our rule of thumb, not a research number: start with two or three stretch tracks an hour and raise it as trust builds.

Where the stretch goes in the set:

☐ After the opening three (trust earned)
☐ Mid-set, between peaks
☐ Late, when the room is committed
☐ Woven through, one at a time

My three stretch directions tonight:

DIRECTION	EXAMPLE	WHY THIS ROOM COULD LOVE IT
A different era of their sound		
A different language, same groove		
A different genre, same energy		

PART C · AFTER THE SET (TWO MINUTES, IN THE CAB)

Which stretch track landed? _____

Which lost the floor (track or bridge)? _____

Next time here, my stretch share: _____

05 · THE BRIDGE-TRACK PLANNER

FAMILIAR → ADJACENT → NEW.

Every stretch needs a bridge. The adjacent track shares one strong thread with the familiar track before it and one new thread with the track after it.

Threads that make a bridge: same groove · same language · same sample, hook or melody · same era · same vocal type · same instrument (dhol, sitar, 808, brass) · same energy level

WORKED EXAMPLE (ILLUSTRATIVE)

FAMILIAR (THEY KNOW IT)	ADJACENT (SHARED THREAD)	NEW (THE STRETCH)
A current Punjabi chart hit	An older bhangra track with the same dhol pattern	A percussive Afro house track with the same swing
Thread: dhol groove →	→ thread: percussion-led swing	

YOUR BRIDGES

#	FAMILIAR	SHARED THREAD	ADJACENT	NEW THREAD	NEW
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					

Escape hatch for each bridge: _____

one familiar track you can return to if the "new" doesn't land

THE CROWD READ · TEN QUESTIONS IN THE FIRST 30 MINUTES

01 Who sings along to the first familiar track, and who doesn't?
02 Are they dancing to the groove or waiting for the hook?
03 Which language gets the loudest reaction?
04 Do phones come out for recognition (filming) or for escape (scrolling)?
05 Is there a sub-group already off the mainstream? (They'll carry your first stretch.)
06 Does the floor hold through an unfamiliar intro, or empty in the first 30 seconds?
07 After a stretch track, does the floor come back for the next familiar one, or stay?
08 Is the bar or the client asking for "the hits", or are you assuming they are?
09 Has anyone come to the booth to ask what a track was? (That's your stretch landing.)
10 Has trust gone up or down since the opening? Move your stretch share to match.

06 · BY CONTEXT

SAME IDEA.
FOUR DIFFERENT ROOMS.

A starting framework, not an exhaustive one.

CLUB · YOUR OWN NIGHT OR A RESIDENCY

The room came for you, so the comfort zone is partly yours already. Stretch wider and earlier. Your regulars' trust is the asset that lets you do it.

Goal: be your city's eclectic station, not its hits station.

WEDDING / SANGEET

Three generations, three different autoplays: the elders' film classics, the parents' 90s and 2000s Bollywood, the cousins' Punjabi, regional and English charts. The bridge is the whole job. Connect generations on a shared thread (the same song in a remix, the same dhol groove, the same language across decades) before you stretch anyone. Keep stretches short and land them between the moments the family has asked for.

Goal: widen the room without losing the aunties or the cousins.

CORPORATE

Mixed teams, many home states, often several languages in one hall. The comfort zone is the most widely shared commercial hits, so stretch through language, not obscurity: a Kannada, Tamil, Telugu or Malayalam track with the same energy as the Hindi hit before it. Clear any stretch direction with the brief first.

Goal: everyone hears one track from “their” language. Nobody feels lost.

OPEN-FORMAT BAR

The tightest comfort zone and the shortest attention spans; people drift in from the street with their feed still in their ears. Use one-track stretches with an instant way back. Watch crowd-read question 06 closely.

Goal: the bar crowd leaves asking what that one track was.

07 · WHAT THIS DOESN'T MEAN

- **It doesn't prove algorithms cause narrow taste.** The Spotify study shows an association, and its authors say so. People might simply use the feed when they want the familiar.
- **It isn't “human good, machine bad”.** Spotify's human editorial playlists sat in the narrower bucket. On Deezer, editors pulled toward the most famous artists and the algorithm pulled the other way.
- **It's not about your dancefloor.** These studies measure people listening on apps, not crowds in a room. Everything on pages 4–6 is our craft reading of the research.
- **It's not Indian data.** The studies cover Spotify (global and US), Deezer (France) and Last.fm. We found no published study of this in India or Asia.
- **It's not a licence to ignore requests.** The comfort zone is where trust comes from. The stretch is only worth something if the room comes with you.

GO DEEPER

Algorithmic Effects on the Diversity of Consumption on Spotify
Anderson, Maystre, Mehrotra, Anderson & Lalmas · The Web Conference (WWW '20), 2020 · cs.utoronto.ca/~ashton/pubs/alg-effects-spotify-www2020.pdf

The core study. Read §4.1 (organic vs programmed) and §4.3 (retention).

Changing Their Tune
Datta, Knox & Bronnenberg · Marketing Science 37(1), 2018 · doi.org/10.1287/mksc.2017.1051

What happened to listening when people switched to streaming.

Follow the Guides: Disentangling Human and Algorithmic Curation
Villermet, Poiroux, Moussallam, Louail & Roth · ACM RecSys 2021 · arxiv.org/abs/2109.03915

The study that complicates the story. Includes the radio comparison.

The Engagement-Diversity Connection
Holtz, Carterette, Chandar, Nazari, Cramer & Aral · 2020 · arxiv.org/abs/2003.08203

A randomised test (on podcasts): personalisation raised listening but narrowed each person's mix.

The Unfairness of Popularity Bias in Music Recommendation
Kowald, Schedl & Lex · ECIR 2020 · arxiv.org/abs/1912.04696

Why listeners with niche taste get the worst recommendations.

Spotify's AI DJ brings a personalised listening experience to the UK and Ireland
Spotify newsroom, 16 May 2023 · newsroom.spotify.com

Primary source for the 25% AI DJ figure.

THE CLOSE

THE FEED PLAYS WHAT THEY ALREADY LIKE. YOU PLAY WHAT THEY'RE ABOUT TO.

You back up every set.
You plan your first three tracks.
You read the room.
Now decide how far you're going to take it.

THE REST OF THE SERIES

No.01 INSURE · Health insurance for working DJs
No.02 RATE · Pricing your work
No.03 TDS · Tax setup for Indian DJs
No.04 CONTRACT · The performance contract
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No.06 BRAIN · The neuroscience of DJing
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No.13 TASTE · Your crowd is on autoplay (this one)

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A note on the science. The research findings are cited to their sources. Everything about sets, crowds and contexts is our craft interpretation for working DJs: not a finding, and not tested on dancefloors.